

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Marketing English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For brand, product marketing, growth, content, SEO, lifecycle, demand generation, marketing operations, social, and agency teams.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

Attribution

Assigning credit to marketing touchpoints for an outcome.

Backlink

A link from another site to your site.

Brand consistency

Maintaining recognizable identity, tone, and promise across touchpoints.

Brand promise

The core expectation a brand creates for customers.

Brand safety

Controls to reduce placement near harmful or unsuitable content.

Buyer journey

Stages a buyer moves through from awareness to evaluation, decision, purchase, and adoption.

CAC

Customer acquisition cost; total acquisition cost divided by new customers, depending on definition.

Campaign idea

The central creative concept connecting message, audience, and execution.

Canonical

Signal indicating the preferred version of similar or duplicate pages.

Cohort

Group of users or customers sharing a time period, behavior, or trait.

Competitive positioning

How the product is framed against alternatives or status quo.

Consent

Permission or legal basis for certain marketing communications or data use.

Content brief

Instructions for a content asset, including audience, intent, angle, claims, proof, and CTA.

CPA

Cost per acquisition or action, depending on the defined conversion.

CPC

Cost per click: advertising cost divided by the counted clicks under the stated measurement method.

CPM

Cost per thousand impressions: advertising cost per one thousand counted ad displays.

Creative brief

Document that guides creative work with audience, objective, insight, message, mandates, and constraints.

Creative fatigue

Declining performance when the audience has seen the same creative too often.

CTA

Call to action; the requested next step for the audience.

CTR

Click-through rate; clicks divided by impressions.

Dark pattern

Design that manipulates or misleads users into choices they may not intend.

Deliverability

Ability of email to reach inboxes and avoid filtering or complaints.

Disclosure

Clear communication of information needed to avoid misleading the audience.

Funnel conversion

Rate at which people move from one stage to the next.

GTM

Go-to-market plan for launching or growing a product, feature, offer, or market motion.

Holding statement

Short approved response used while facts are still being confirmed.

ICP

Ideal customer profile; the type of account or customer most likely to succeed and create value.

Incrementality

Additional outcome caused by marketing that would not have happened otherwise.

Influenced pipeline

Pipeline where marketing touched the opportunity, depending on model.

Insight

A non-obvious customer truth or tension that can guide strategy or creative work.

Internal linking

Links between pages on the same site to help users and search engines navigate.

JTBD

Jobs to be done; what the customer is trying to accomplish in a situation.

Keyword

A word or phrase targeted because people search for it.

Launch tier

Level of launch investment and support based on business impact and complexity.

Lead

A person or account showing some level of interest or fit.

Lift test

Experiment estimating causal impact by comparing exposed and control groups.

Material connection

Relationship such as payment, employment, or free product that may require disclosure.

Messaging hierarchy

Ordered structure of headline, value proposition, pillars, proof points, and CTA.

Metadata

Page title, description, and other information that helps describe content.

SQL

Marketing-qualified lead based on agreed fit and engagement criteria.

Nurture

Planned communication that develops interest or readiness over time.

Objection handling

Language and proof used to respond to buyer concerns.

Open rate

Percentage of delivered emails recorded as opened, with known measurement limitations.

Opt-out

Process allowing people to stop receiving certain communications.

Persona

A model of a target user, buyer, or influencer used to guide messaging and content.

Positioning

How a brand or product should be understood relative to alternatives.

Proof point

Evidence that supports a claim, such as data, customer story, demo, or benchmark.

Retargeting

Advertising to people who previously interacted with the brand or site.

ROAS

Return on ad spend; revenue attributed to ads divided by ad spend.

Sales enablement

Materials and training that help sales communicate value and move opportunities forward.

Search intent

The likely goal behind a search query.

Segment

A meaningful subset of the market based on shared traits, needs, behavior, or value.

Segmentation

Dividing contacts or accounts into groups for relevant communication.

SERP

Search engine results page: the page displaying results for a search query.

Sourced pipeline

Pipeline credited to marketing as the original source, depending on model.

SQL

Sales-qualified lead accepted or qualified by sales for active pursuit.

Substantiation

Evidence supporting express or implied advertising claims before launch.

Suppression list

List of contacts excluded from campaigns because of opt-out, risk, irrelevance, or policy.

TAM

Total addressable market; the broad revenue opportunity if the product served the whole market.

Tone of voice

The brand's consistent style of expression across channels.

Use case

A specific situation where a customer uses the product to solve a problem.

Value proposition

Specific value promised to a specific audience, supported by proof.

Vanity metric

Metric that looks impressive but does not support a real decision.

Win-loss insight

Learning from deals won or lost to improve positioning, product, or sales execution.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Transfer information and responsibility

The current status is ...; the outstanding item is

The record shows

Please confirm who has accepted

State the current situation, relevant background, open task, and receiving role. Ask for acknowledgment or repeat-back of the critical item. Sending a message and transferring responsibility are not always the same thing.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Repair a misunderstanding

My earlier message did not make ... clear.

I'm sorry for The correct information is

Let me check that the revised explanation addresses

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Marketing Strategy: Audience, Insight, Problem, Outcome

A campaign brief targets "everyone who works in an office." The product is a scheduling tool, but the buyer and daily user may differ.

Who decides to buy the tool, and who uses it each day? Let's define a specific audience and the problem we are solving before choosing the campaign message.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Positioning, Messaging, Brand Voice, and Proof

A draft advertisement says "the fastest tool on the market." The only evidence is an internal test against one earlier version.

The test supports a comparison with our earlier version, not the whole market. Could we use a narrower claim that accurately describes what we measured and send it for review?

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

03 | Campaign Briefs, GTM Planning, and Cross-Functional Alignment

A launch brief has a date and channel list but no audience, approved message, or measure of success.

Could you add the primary audience, approved message, and success measure before Thursday's review? Those details will help the content and channel teams work toward the same outcome.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Content, SEO, Thought Leadership, and Editorial Judgment

A proposed article targets a popular keyword, but searchers appear to want instructions while the draft is a product announcement.

The search intent appears to be instructional. Our draft announces a product instead. We could create a useful how-to article and include the product only where it helps answer the question.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

05 | Paid Media, Performance Marketing, and Attribution

Paid conversions rose after a campaign change, but a discount began in the same week. A slide credits the campaign with the entire increase.

Conversions rose after the campaign change, but the discount is another possible influence. I'll describe the timing accurately and avoid claiming that the campaign caused the entire increase.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

06 | Lifecycle, CRM, Email, Marketing Ops, and Sales Handoff

A lead list is ready for sales. It contains contact details but no explanation of which contacts requested a conversation.

The handoff needs the agreed qualification fields and contact permissions. I'll distinguish conversation requests from other activity so sales can choose an appropriate follow-up under our process.

Try it again: The intended recipient cannot take ownership. Keep the status clear and identify the need for an authorized reassignment.

07 | Analytics, Experimentation, Funnel Reporting, and Executive Readouts

An email experiment records 120 clicks from 2,000 delivered messages in version A and 140 from 2,000 in version B. No significance analysis is complete.

The observed click rates are 6% and 7%. Version B is higher in this sample, but we have not established whether the difference is reliable. Let's complete the planned analysis before naming a winner.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

08 | Compliance, Privacy, Claims, Influencers, Brand Safety, and Crisis Response

A scheduled post includes a claim that reviewers have asked to revise. The post has not yet been published.

The scheduled wording differs from the reviewed claim. I'll pause publication through our process and send the revised copy for approval. Please confirm which version should replace it.

Try it again: The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.